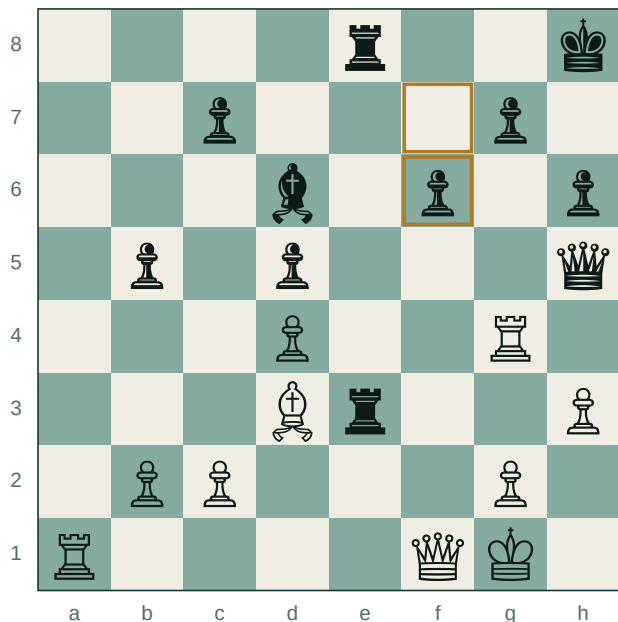


Trapping a piece: White, move 31

Trapping a piece

White to move



Previous move: 30...f6. Gold borders mark its start and finish.

WORKED CONTINUATION - COVER THIS SECTION FIRST

31. Bg6 Qxg6 32. Rxg6

31.Bg6 The bishop moves from d3 to g6. From g6 it attacks queen on h5 and rook on e8. Recorded reply: **31...Qxg6**.

32.Rxg6 The rook captures the queen on g6.

At the end, nominal material is White 24 / Black 19 (P=1, N/B=3, R=5, Q=9). Over this line, White's balance changes by +6. Activity and king safety still affect the evaluation.

CHECKPOINT

Using P=1, N/B=3, R=5, Q=9, how much does White's material balance change over the complete line? **Answer:** +6: the balance goes from -1 to +5. Count promotions and every recapture, not just the first gain.

CARRY THE IDEA INTO YOUR GAMES

An attacked piece is not trapped if it can give check, trade itself favorably, or open an escape through a sacrifice.

WHAT THIS POSITION TEACHES

A trapped piece lacks safe retreat squares. Winning it usually requires restricting its routes before attacking it, or forcing it into a cage.

HOW TO LOOK

Trace every plausible escape square for the target, including captures and counterchecks. Then find the move that closes the remaining route.

The defending king is on h8. Geometrically undefended: queen on h5. Check for tactical protection.